

- Disney has used recent Nielsen research to challenge conventional ideas about the ethnic diversity in mainstream America. 53% of Americans live in a multicultural or 'blended' household. 67% indicated they were enthusiastic about encountering and experimenting with '**diverse cultures**'.
- Think about recent Disney releases like *Moana* (2016) or *Coco* (2017): how do they represent a **cultural tradition** positively? What **universal** themes or story elements would audiences not from that culture still engage with?

Consider the regulatory framework of contemporary media in the UK and the role of regulation in global production, distribution and circulation:

- The **BBFC** (an independent, non-governmental body) **classifies** film and video releases in the UK. However, local councils have the power to overrule BBFC decisions and rate films differently (e.g. *This is England* was rated 18 by the BBFC but several councils rated it 15).
- The theatrical release of *Black Panther* gained a **12a certificate**. Look at the BBFC website for what constitutes a 12a - why do you think they awarded this to *Black Panther*? (<http://www.bbfc.co.uk/>)
- The film, like many recent Marvel films, features very little romantic drama and no sex or nudity. It is fairly violent, but the combat is fantastical (hard to imitate) and there is a strong **moral code** to most of the conflict. The film was classified as PG-13 in USA, and similarly in other territories. Why do you think the film was regulated this way, even in countries with stricter rules and censorship like China or India?

Consider processes of production, distribution and circulation and the impact of digitally convergent platforms:

- The **teaser trailer** was released in June 2017 by Disney's sister channel ABC, during NBA Finals. Within 24 hours it had been viewed 89 million times on Youtube.
- Just before release, *Black Panther* was the most-tweeted about film of 2018 with more than 5 million tweets globally. In mid-March 2018, it became the most-tweeted

about film ever with 35 million tweets.

Consider how film/film marketing is circulated and distributed:

- Where and how is film/film marketing most likely to be **consumed** by audiences?
- How has this **consumption** changed/ been impacted by the internet, including YouTube and smartphones?
- Are audiences now more likely to seek out, for example, new trailers online as **active consumers**? (Think about 'reaction' videos of people watching trailers!)
- Consider the way people **share** trailers or movie gossip (casting decisions, plot elements etc.) especially those with a strong **fan community**. How is this an example of '**word-of-mouth**' marketing.
- How does this impact the relationship between audience and product?
- How did *Black Panther* harness other, more political **social media campaigns** to create a 'cultural event' rather than just another summer blockbuster?

Theoretical perspectives:

A level only:

Cultural industries - David Hesmondhalgh

- Further explore the concept of profit in relation to the film industry and in this case specifically to the film **franchises**. Often films within a series can become formulaic and lack risk. Is this the case with Marvel Studios? Or Disney?
- Explore Hesmondhalgh's idea that media conglomerates operate across a range of cultural industries by considering the way the film was released as part of a **synergy** - with fashion, music, videogames, sports tie-ins, even a car!
- You might also usefully introduce the idea that this film has a very low risk for the producers. The character of T'Challa and Wakanda were introduced in *Captain America: Civil War*, the comic is over 50 years old, and all previous Marvel films have been hugely successful. On the other hand, having such an **Afrocentric** film could have been seen as a commercial risk, especially outside the USA and Africa.